



HIGH AND DRY

■ By Sandeep Unnithan

We have time for two more sorties," Captain Kamal Kishore Bansal looks up at the grey evening sky and hops into the cockpit of the bright yellow Cessna with trainee pilot Gaurav Chaudhary. They putter down the 1-km patch of concrete set in a breathtakingly bucolic emerald swath of rice fields, 7 km from Karnal in Haryana. The sortie will take at least an hour. Four students from Delhi and Chandigarh sit awaiting their turn to fly.

In most flying schools in the world, where aircraft and instructors are available in plenty, it would take less than six months for these young pilots to notch up the requisite 200 flying hours to get a Commercial Pilot's Licence (CPL). But at Karnal, they have to wait between 12 and 18 months. Why? Against a requirement of at least 10 flying instructors for its fleet of five aircraft, the club—run by the Haryana Government—has just one instructor, the multi-tasking Captain Bansal, who juggles flight training, administration,

handles telephone enquiries and worries about catching enough sleep for the night flying classes.

The situation is similar in flying clubs across the country. India's aviation sector, growing at 12 per cent annually, needs at least 1,000 new pilots every year to fly the Boeings and Airbuses it is importing. In just two years, 135 new aircraft have been added. With starting salaries of Rs 1.5 lakh per month, there has never been a better time to become a

commercial pilot. Now with a pilot crunch, airlines are turning towards foreign pilots to fill their cockpits. To meet the demand, nearly 500 foreign pilots have been hired at nearly twice the salaries and perks of their Indian counterparts.

"The sudden aviation boom has far outstripped the training infrastructure," admits Kanu Gohain, Director-General Civil Aviation (DGCA). There are 42 training institutes in India but 16 are defunct. Of the 26 operational institutes, 14 are run by state governments and one—the Indira Gandhi Rashtriya Uran Akademi (IGRUA)—is an autonomous society under the Central Government. The remaining 11 institutes are run by private entrepreneurs. IGRUA has 22 aircraft but produces just 40 pilots every year because it has only two instructors.

The sad state of these flying institutes is only one part of the larger malaise hampering the rapid growth of the civil aviation sector. In Punjab, the former hub of defence and civil aviation, the Amritsar, Ludhiana and Jalandhar flying clubs have closed

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■ Total number of flying clubs in India: **42**

■ Defunct clubs: **16**

■ Number of pilot licences issued in India every year: **368**

■ Number of new pilots required every year: **1,000**

■ Time taken to get a licence in Indian flying club: **12-18 months**

■ Time taken in a foreign academy: **Less than six months**